

# Buffalo Beacon — Vision & Strategy

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*A verified, real-time board of open shelters, food pantries, and warming centers — built for the neighbors and frontline helpers who get people to safety, especially when a storm turns every other channel to noise.*

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## 1. The thesis in one paragraph

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During an emergency, the scarce resource is not information — it's **trustworthy, current, findable** information. When a Buffalo storm hits, help *does* exist: churches open their basements, pantries hand out food, rec centers become warming shelters. But that help is announced through a hundred scattered Facebook posts, hand-written signs, and word of mouth. The people who most need it — the elderly, the isolated, the unhoused, people without reliable internet — are the least able to piece it together in the moment. Buffalo Beacon is the layer that organizes that chaos: a single, verified, real-time source that the people who *help* others can trust and amplify.

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## 2. The problem, and why it's real

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In December 2022, Winter Storm Elliott killed **more than 40 people in Erie County** — one of the deadliest weather events in Buffalo's history. Many died stranded in cars or collapsed trying to walk for help, sometimes within blocks of a warm building. Buffalo's identity is "we dig each other out," and during Elliott people *did* mobilize — organizing rescues on Twitter and Facebook, turning local news into an informal switchboard. The will was there. The **coordination** was not.

The gap is specific and it repeats every winter:

- A church decides at 4pm to open its doors for the night. **How does a cold, frightened person three neighborhoods away find out in time?**
- A pantry has hot food and toiletries today. **How does that reach the family that needs it, when it's not on Google, not on any official list, just a post buried in a feed?**
- A volunteer with a truck wants to help. **How do they get matched to the people who actually need a ride?**

Today the answer is "scroll and hope." That's not a system. That's the absence of one.

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### 3. What Buffalo Beacon actually is

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A simple web platform with two sides:

**For organizations** (shelters, pantries, warming centers, churches):

- Log in with a one-click email link — no passwords.
- Update status in seconds: open/closed, hours, what's offered.
- Post to a **community board**: ask for help (volunteers, donations) or share news (an event, a warm-meal night).
- Every update instantly publishes to the public page, emails subscribers, and generates a ready-to-post tweet they can share with one click.

**For the public and the people who help them:**

- A clean page showing who's open *right now*, with a map and one-tap directions.
- Subscribe to specific orgs and get an email the moment they open.
- A community board showing where to volunteer, what's needed, and what's happening.

Every listed org carries a ✓ **Verified** badge — because in a crisis, "is this real and current?" is the only question that matters.

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### 4. How it helps — by who's actually using it

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The mistake most "help apps" make is designing for the person in crisis as the primary user. That person, at their lowest moment, will not discover and adopt a new app. So Beacon is designed around the people who **reach** them:

| Who                                                      | What they get                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>211 operators, social workers, ER discharge staff</b> | A reliable, structured, current source to point people to — better than a phone tree or a stale PDF.                  |
| <b>Church &amp; mutual-aid volunteers</b>                | One place to see who needs hands today, and to broadcast their own org's status without crafting five separate posts. |
| <b>Worried family members</b>                            | "Where can Grandma go tonight?" answered in one page instead of a panicked round of phone calls.                      |

| Who                                   | What they get                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Civically-engaged Buffalonians</b> | A low-effort way to <i>be</i> the neighbor who helps — follow, and when a storm hits you can relay open shelters in one click.                                               |
| <b>The person in crisis</b>           | Reached <i>indirectly and reliably</i> — through the helpers above, and through the platforms they already use, rather than depending on them to find a brand-new app alone. |

This is the core design decision: **Beacon's job is to arm the amplifiers, not to be discovered by the sufferer.** You reach a few hundred helpers; each one touches dozens of vulnerable people. That's the multiplier.

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## 5. The gaps it covers that nothing else does

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Beacon is not competing with the tools people already use — it fills the seam *between* them. Here's the honest comparison:

- **211 / phone hotlines** — Authoritative but slow. Not real-time, not searchable, and can't tell you whether *this specific church* is open *tonight*. Great for referral; useless for "right now."
- **Twitter / Facebook** — Where the info actually gets posted, but unstructured, unverified, and ephemeral. A life-saving post from six hours ago is buried under noise. You cannot filter "open shelters near 14211." Rumors spread as fast as facts.
- **Google Maps** — A phone book of permanent locations. It shows a shelter *exists*; it never shows whether it's *open and accepting people this hour*. Pop-up warming centers — the ones that matter most in a storm — don't exist on Maps at all.
- **Nextdoor / neighborhood groups** — Siloed, hyper-local, and skew toward homeowners, not the populations most at risk.

**Beacon's unique position:** verified + live + structured + pushed. It takes the information that's already being shouted into the void and makes it trustworthy, current, and reachable at the moment of need. Same reason restaurant-reservation apps didn't die when Google Maps listed restaurants — *knowing a place exists is different from knowing you can get in right now.*

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## 6. Why people will use it

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**Organizations will, because it saves a harried person time in a crisis.** During a storm, a volunteer coordinator doesn't want to write a tweet, remember to update it when they close, *and* separately text their regulars. Beacon does all three from one box. The ask isn't "please adopt my app" — it's "type once, reach everyone." That's a real workflow win, not a favor.

**Helpers will, because it's the reliable source they currently lack.** Anyone whose job or role involves getting people to safety is constantly hunting for current info. A trustworthy board beats a Facebook search every time.

**Amplifiers will follow, because it lets them help with near-zero effort** — and because it taps something real in Buffalo: the pride of being a city that takes care of its own. Following Beacon and relaying "St. Luke's is open tonight" is a way to live that identity.

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## 7. Why people *won't* use it — and how we design around that

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An honest document names the failure modes. Here are the real ones:

- **"I'd just post on Twitter — I don't know Beacon exists."** True, and fatal *if* Beacon tries to be a destination people go to instead of Twitter. So it doesn't. **Beacon feeds Twitter** — the org posts once, and Beacon hands them a pre-written tweet to their own account. We ride the platforms people already use rather than fighting them for attention.
- **The cold-start problem: empty platforms are useless.** Beacon needs orgs before it's valuable. But the org universe is small and knowable — roughly **60 shelters and pantries in Erie County** — and reachable by direct outreach (a phone call, a warm intro), not a marketing budget. You don't need 10,000 users; you need ~60 orgs and a handful of partner endorsements.
- **A tool that matters twice a winter gets forgotten.** Real risk. Addressed by the community board (Section 8) — food insecurity and volunteering are year-round, giving people a reason to stay engaged between storms.
- **The person in crisis has no smartphone or data.** Correct, and why Beacon does **not** bet on that person self-serving. It reaches them through the helpers and, in a later phase, through SMS and partner channels (211, county lines) that meet people where they are.
- **Misinformation could get someone hurt.** If a listing says "open" when it isn't, that's dangerous. This is exactly why **only verified, admin-onboarded orgs can post** — no open signup, no anonymous "we're open" claims. Verification isn't a feature; it's the safety mechanism.

Naming these openly is the point: the design is *shaped by* the objections, not blind to them.

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## 8. How it stays effective all the time (not just during storms)

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A storm-only tool has terrible staying power. Beacon earns year-round relevance through two ongoing needs that don't require a blizzard:

1. **Food is a year-round emergency for a real population.** Pantries operate every week. "What's available near me this week" is a live, recurring need — the same infrastructure, used continuously.
2. **The help-out side keeps the amplifiers engaged.** The community board lets orgs post "we need coat donations" or "two volunteers needed Saturday." That's content people who *want to help* will follow and share — and they're precisely the amplifiers who make the platform work when a storm does hit.

The pattern: **storms are how Beacon gets discovered; food and volunteering are how it stays followed.** By the time the next Elliott arrives, the audience is already there.

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## 9. The moat: verification and trust

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Anyone can build a list of shelters. What's hard to copy is being the *trusted* one. In an emergency, information is only useful if you believe it. Beacon's verified-orgs-only model means a Beacon post is authoritative in a way a random tweet never can be. Over time, "check Beacon" becomes shorthand for "get the real answer" — and that trust, earned org by org and storm by storm, is the durable advantage. It's also why partners (211, the county, the homeless coalition) can comfortably link to it: they're pointing people to verified sources, not a rumor mill.

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## 10. How it actually reaches people (distribution)

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Beacon will not win through consumer advertising, and it doesn't need to. Distribution comes from **borrowing audiences that already exist**:

- **One link from a trusted hub** — 211 WNY, the WNY Coalition for the Homeless, or the county's Code Blue page — puts Beacon in front of exactly the right people. That single placement is worth more than any ad spend.
- **The amplifiers redistribute it** — every helper who shares an open-shelter update is doing the last-mile distribution the platform can't buy.
- **The orgs' own followers** — when an org posts its Beacon-generated update to their Twitter/Facebook, their existing community sees it.

This is the same warm-introduction path used to recruit the orgs in the first place: relationships, not marketing.

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## 11. How this could fail — and the honest mitigations

| Risk                                                | Mitigation                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Orgs sign up but don't keep status updated          | Make updating effortless (one box, one click) and valuable (it posts everywhere for them). Stale data is the enemy; low-friction updates are the defense. |
| Nobody's watching during the one storm that matters | Build the following <i>before</i> via the year-round board and partner links, so the audience is warm when it counts.                                     |
| It becomes "just a directory" Maps does better      | Stay ruthlessly focused on <i>live status</i> and <i>notifications</i> — the things Maps can't do. Don't waste effort being a prettier phone book.        |
| A false "open" listing harms someone                | Verified orgs only; no anonymous posting; clear timestamps so users see how fresh a status is.                                                            |
| One person (you) can't run it forever               | Design it to be low-maintenance and hand-off-able; document everything (this repo already does).                                                          |

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## 12. What "working" looks like

Concrete signals, not vanity metrics:

- **Supply:** a meaningful share of Erie County's ~60 orgs onboarded and actually updating.
- **Trust:** at least one recognized partner (211, county, a coalition) linking to or endorsing Beacon.
- **Engagement between storms:** community-board posts and subscribers growing in non-emergency months.
- **The moment of truth:** during the next real storm, Beacon is a source people *reach for and relay* — measured in updates posted, alerts sent, and shares.
- **The only metric that ultimately matters:** someone found a warm place, or a hot meal, because Beacon told them where — when they wouldn't have known otherwise.

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## 13. Where it goes from here

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- **Now:** verified orgs, live status, map, email alerts, one-click share, community board — all built and working.
  - **Next:** onboard real Erie County orgs (starting from the outreach list), secure one partner link, go live before winter.
  - **Later:** SMS alerts (meets at-risk users where they are), automated social posting (if it ever justifies the paid API), and — only if Buffalo proves it — the same model generalized to other disaster types and cities (hurricanes, tornadoes), where the core "verified live status + amplifiers" pattern applies unchanged.
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## The bottom line

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Buffalo Beacon isn't trying to be a social network, a mental-health app, or a prettier Google Maps. It's a narrow, honest fix for a documented, deadly gap: **when help opens its doors during a storm, the people who need it can't reliably find out in time.** It works by arming the helpers, feeding the platforms people already use, earning trust through verification, and staying alive year-round through the everyday work of food and volunteering. That's not a bummy website. That's a piece of civic infrastructure a city like Buffalo should have had already.